CHAPTER TWO:
BROTHERS IN ARMS

Iron Man's comic book supporting cast has had a long and storied history. We met some of them in the first film, but it's in Iron Man 2 that Tony Stark's friends and allies really come into their own. Joining Pepper Potts (played by Gwyneth Paltrow) and Happy Hogan (played by Director Jon Favreau) are some of the best friends a guy in a multi-billion-dollar suit of armor could ask for.

With War Machine, Black Widow, and Nick Fury joining the fray, Tony Stark might have a chance after all. But the creative minds behind Iron Man 2 were aware of some of the dangers of over-loading the audience with a new cast.

Kevin Feige explains, "There have been good sequels, there have been not-so-good sequels, and what we've learned (and we learned early on) is you can't just feel the pressure to add the new character—add in this fan favorite, put in this new villain. You'll collapse very quickly under the weight of all your characters, of all your plotlines, of everything you're trying to service."

Instead, while the audience is excited about seeing new characters, the filmmakers have to be careful. "What we try to do," says Feige, "and what I think we've achieved in Iron Man 2, is only introduce new characters that will have an impact on your main characters. Which will make it more interesting to watch your main characters deal with the new curveballs being thrown at them by these new characters you've introduced."

Executive Producer Louis D'Esposito sums up the benefits of adding to the cast: "There's always this need to top yourself, and sometimes that can get in the way a little bit. But look at our cast right now—it is phenomenal. I have friends that are in the industry call me up and say, 'You're making a serious drama over there with the actors that you have,' or 'You're making an art film; you're not making a super hero movie.'" It's exactly that special chemistry that makes the Iron Man franchise what it is."



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